

BJP, and the Vokkaligas, who voted mainly for the Janata Dal (Secular) or the JD(S), the third force in the state that often played kingmaker (and, occasionally, king) with 30-40 seats.

The BJP stole a march when in October 2022, nearly seven months before the polls, the Bommai government promulgated an ordinance to increase reservations in employment and education for Scheduled Castes by 2 per cent and for Scheduled Tribes by 4 per cent. Then, in what Bommai described as a masterstroke, a day before the polls were announced, he scrapped reservations for Muslims and redistributed the four per cent thus freed among the Lingayats and Vokkaligas, in the hope that it would also strengthen the party's Hindutva vote.

Tinkering with reservations, AMI's Gupta will tell you, is fraught with danger for any government. The backlash this time came from the Other Backward Classes, who felt they had been left out in the whole process. Sections of the SCs, too, were aggrieved with the way the percentage reserved for them was redistributed among the four groups. An examination of the social group-wise support based on INDIA TODAY-AMI exit poll numbers shows that the Congress cornered a massive share of the Ahinda vote. The BJP won just 12 of the 36 SC seats and none of the 15 ST seats. The Congress, on the other hand, won 21 SC seats and 14 ST seats, respectively, up from the 12 SC seats and eight ST seats it won in 2018.

Meanwhile, having Shivakumar, a Vokkaliga, at the helm, helped fetch more votes from the community, to the detriment of the JD(S). He also made overtures across a traditional divide, making the powerful Lingayat leader M.B. Patil chairperson of the Congress campaign committee, thus helping the party secure the vote of the other dominant community. The BJP, on the other hand, had run into issues with its Lingayat base when it sidelined Yediyurappa and the party high command decided to drop senior leaders like Jagadish Shettar and Laxman Savadi. The party had wanted to bring about a generational change in its traditional Lingayat base and experiment with new faces to expand its Vokkaliga base. However, both these efforts met with limited success. The Congress made significant inroads into the BJP's Lingayat base with 34 MLAs from this community, even as the BJP's tally was reduced to 18.

LESSON 6: POLARISATION CAN GO ONLY SO FAR

Right through the election campaign, the Congress took care to focus on local issues. Its leaders were aware that with Prime Minister Narendra Modi as its mascot, the BJP would try to shift the narrative towards national security and unity. Surjewala instructed party campaigners to stick to the agreed narrative and say "nothing sensational—no Adani, no Modi, no Ambani, not a word".

The Congress did slip at one point, when it mentioned the Bajrang Dal in the same breath as the Popular Front of India (PFI) as organisations that could be banned. That gave the BJP a chance to raise the familiar bogey of Muslim appeasement and Hindu-baiting. The party, and Modi in particular, went to town accusing the Congress of being anti-Hindu and against Hanuman or Bajrang Bali, a revered deity. 'Jai Bajrang Bali' became a rallying cry for the BJP, and, for a while, it seemed as though the Congress had yet again snatched defeat from the jaws of victory.

It seemed to undo all the restraint the Congress had exhibited earlier. The Grand Old Party had, for instance, maintained a calculated silence when the hijab and halal controversies broke out last year. Leaders were told not to comment on the debate, leaving the Muslim community, which constitutes 13 per cent of the state's population, upset with the Congress for not taking a strong stand on the issue. The inclusion of Bajrang Dal in the manifesto this time was something key Congress leaders were well aware of. It was a balancing act the party was hoping to achieve since the BJP's campaign was forcing it to take a hard stand on the PFI. They thought they had couched it in vague enough terms, but the eagle-eyed BJP swooped on it nevertheless.

The Congress decided not to join issue with the BJP on the matter. Gaurav Vallabh, its articulate communications head, says, "When Modi talked of 91 *gaali*s and Hanuman Chalisa, we talked of 40 per cent commission of the BJP and our five guarantees." As it turned out, the issue backfired on the BJP